



Commencement 2026

On Saturday, May 16, tassels were turned, diplomas joyfully received, and voices raised in praise as we celebrated another graduating class at the WELS College of Ministry. Bachelor's degrees were awarded to 43 pre-seminary, 86 education, and five staff ministry graduates. One student earned an associate degree in education, and 30 more marked the completion of their master's degrees in education, educational administration, and theology.

Basing his sermon on the class passage, 2 Corinthians 4:5-7, President Rich Gurgel reminded the graduates that their ministries will not be about themselves, but about Jesus: **"For what we preach is not ourselves, but Jesus Christ as Lord, and ourselves as your servants for Jesus' sake."** He also reminded them that, as gospel ministers, they are just "jars of clay," fragile and weak. But they hold a great treasure: Jesus' love and forgiveness, which they are called to pour out to others, just as it's been poured into them.

Assignments

At the Call Service on May 16 and in the days immediately following, 79 graduates were assigned to teaching ministries and three graduates were assigned to staff ministries. Another 17 graduates of previous years were reassigned to teaching ministries. Additional graduates may be assigned throughout the summer. Many vacancies across the synod remain: as of May 21, 77 teacher calls and six staff ministry calls remain unfilled.

Our videographers have captured the big day in a cinematic recap, featuring highlights from the Commencement Service and the Call Service.

SCAN THE QR CODE TO WATCH THE VIDEO >



Old Main's New Welcome

The new entrance to Old Main is complete! Foundation repairs and a covered stairwell now provide a safe and weather-protected walkway—one that honors the historic aesthetic of this iconic 1884 building.

Here's to many more Old Main memories and milestones!



SPRING HIGHLIGHTS



*Congratulations,
Rachel Schoeneck!*

Senior soccer and tennis player Rachel Schoeneck earned a prestigious honor: the UMAC's 2026 Women's Scholar-Athlete Leadership Award, which recognizes athletes' leadership on the field, excellence in the classroom, and service to the community.

Men's Track & Field Dominate UMAC

For the second year in a row, the MLC men's outdoor track and field team clinched first place at the UMAC Outdoor Championships—this time by more than 50 points. Congrats also go to Breanna Olson and her staff for notching UMAC Coaching Staff of the Year.

Dual Credit Launches

MLS and LPS students received both high school and college credit for their Modern West and Elementary Statistics courses this year, and we're adding two more dual-credit courses in 2026-2027: Intro to Fine Arts at MLS and a psychology course at Fox Valley LHS.

Staff Ministry Expansions

We're planning to launch a 3+2 program with Bethany Lutheran College in 2027, enabling students to earn a BS Staff Ministry and an MA Clinical Mental Health Counseling in five years. We're also exploring an online minor in social media/marketing, which will have strong applications to ministry.

Worldwide MLC + DAY

MAY 6, 2026

Boosted by several matching gifts from generous donors, we set a goal of \$210,000 for MLC Day. By God's grace, we not only reached that goal—we **shattered it!**

Together, MLC friends and supporters gave more than **\$302,000** toward the matching fund for the Congregational Partner Grant Program—a tremendous show of support for our students being Knighted for Ministry!

Watch our thank-you video here!



Retiring Faculty

We're grateful for the service of these retiring professors:



Brian Dose
English
36 years



Lawrence Olson
Staff Ministry
33 years



Joel Thomford
Admissions
7 years

New Faculty

We're excited to welcome these new faculty members this fall:

Holly Dannecker
Special Ed

Mark Parsons
English

Alyssa Warnke
ECLC Lead Teacher

Kevin Walker
Staff Ministry
Director

Jack Heichelbech
Tutor



1995 Luther Court, New Ulm MN 56073
507.354.8221

If you have any questions, please contact us at mlcinfo@mlc-wels.edu.

mlc-wels.edu